

SMART CARDS

Plug Loopholes

With as porous a border and as diverse an economy as India's, security and governance are always key issues. Smart IDs are promising to help government agencies tackle these challenges better. E-governance, along with telecom, is one of the largest markets for smart cards, and also seems to be driving certain technological advancements therein

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What is a smart card?

A smart card or token is like a visiting card with a tiny computer chip inside it.

It can store information and communicate with smart card terminals that can read and write information to the card, as well as act as the interface between the smart card and a larger network or application.

A smart card is highly secure, and is often combined with even higher levels of security such as biometric identification.

At a basic level, a smart card can perform some or all of four functions: data storage, identification, authentication and application processing.

Depending on the information stored, and coupled with appropriate smart card terminals and software, the same smart card can be used for multiple applications.

In an ideal situation, a person would carry just a single smart card that acts as a credit card, cash card, ration card, PAN card, voter's ID, SIM card and even passport. However, such an implementation would require a concerted effort by various agencies, including government and private ones, along with adherence to several common standards and regulations.

We have a long way to go in this regard, but a beginning has been made through the inception and implementation of the Unique Identity Authority of India (UIDAI).

If we had a 'smart' identification card instead, it would mean a very secure, unique identity with the potential to replace several individual cards issued in a decentralised and *ad-hoc* fashion by various agencies. "A smart card combines three functions: identification, authentication and data storage. It could work as a multipurpose card that merges all other cards. Plus, it is highly secure. Smart ID cards prevent identity theft and are important in terms of national security," explains Sandeep Lugani, practice head-Intelligent Building Management System & Physical Security, Wipro-India, Middle East and Africa.

As the technology is reasonably mature, this is indeed the right time to introduce smart IDs, and learn about the challenges and opportunities it throws open to the tech fraternity in India.

Have you ever searched the Web for 'fake passport'? You will find agencies selling fake passports (and openly advertising it online), supposedly for use by private detectives for legally-permitted levels of espionage. However, we all know that fake passports are put to more dangerous uses! Pawnbrokers and local rogues confiscate the ration cards of villagers and use it to procure groceries at low prices. Such examples make you wonder whether the traditional ID cards really serve the purposes of identification and authentication.